“extreme recklessness.” The instruction was corrected in line with Khrushchev’s objection.[10]

Both the Mikoyan memoirs and the protocol of the meeting suggest that not all nuclear weapons were ruled out. “Make all the effort initially not to use atomic [weaponry]. If there is a landing assault—the tactical atomic weaponry, but the strategic [not] until orders are given [from Moscow],” reads the protocol of the meeting. What Khrushchev and others had in mind when they talked about tactical weapons were the Luna nuclear-tipped missiles, which had already been delivered to the island. As for strategic forces, they explicitly excluded from their order the “means in the custody of Statsenko.” The reference was to the R-12 missile regiments already deployed in Cuba under the command of General Igor Statsenko. Malinovsky proposed not to rush with an order before Kennedy’s announcement: “[W]ait until 1:00 a.m., or else they will be given grounds for using atomic weaponry.”[11]

Khrushchev and his colleagues were now waiting for Kennedy’s speech. They were ready for the worst, and, while maintaining control over strategic nuclear weapons, were prepared to allow Soviet commanders in Cuba to use tactical ones. The mood in the Kremlin was close to panic. “That’s it. Lenin’s work has been destroyed,” was Khrushchev’s first reaction to the American discovery of the Cuban missiles, as recalled by his KGB chief, Vladimir Semichastny.[12]

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THE SOVIET AMBASSADOR TO WASHINGTON, ANATOLY Dobrynin, received a message from Dean Rusk to come to his office in the State Department at 6:00 p.m. that day. It was the afternoon of October 22, and Dobrynin was in New York, seeing off the departing Soviet foreign minister, Andrei Gromyko, who was returning to Moscow with the upbeat message that there were no developments concerning Cuba. Dobrynin tried to move the meeting to the next day, but Rusk’s messenger insisted on seeing the Soviet ambassador that evening. Dobrynin suspected that something important had happened, but he did not know what.